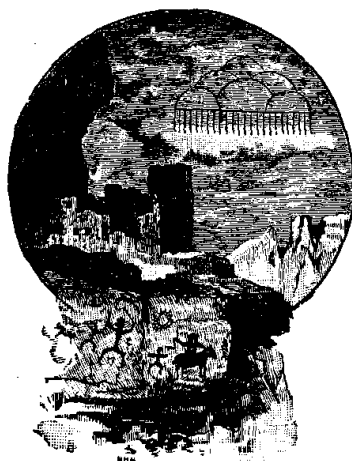


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HANDBOOK
OF THE
INDIANS OF CALIFORNIA

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SOCIAL PRACTICES.

As in the whole of southern California, social institutions constitute the least known side of Gabrielino culture. Marriage was by purchase, but more was made of the wedding rite than of the payment; chiefs and prominent men often had several wives. All this is typical Juaneño procedure. The wife seems to have lived in the husband's village. It is said that he was at liberty to punish her at will for infidelity, even by death; but that the usual solution was to leave her to the seducer and appropriate the latter's spouse, with which practice no interference was tolerated. Deliberate incest was punished by shooting to death. There was a chief in each village. If any exercised wider influence, the fact has not been reported. To judge by Juaneño analogues, as well as the above-mentioned titles for the chieftain's children, the position conveyed much deference and respect. Each chief was known by the name of his town plus the suffix *-pik* or *-vik*. The rank was hereditary, apparently in the male line. It is said that the chief took no action against sorcerers, other than to leave punishment to the magical machinations of the medicine men of his own town. As an absolute negative, this statement may be doubted. It is likely to have been true under the outward restraints of mission life.

Captives taken in battle were tortured and killed.

The hair was at times plastered with clay for 24 hours, to impart gloss and keep it from splitting. The Mohave mix in a vegetable dye for this purpose; plain mud is applied by them to kill vermin.

The dead were burned by both Fernandeño and Gabrielino proper until the padres introduced interment. On Santa Catalina many skeletons have been found, but few if any evidences of cremation. Burial must therefore have been the prevalent manner on this island through most of its history. The mainland, on the other hand, is remarkably free of ancient human bones, except at immediate coast points opposite Santa Catalina, such as Topanga, Santa Monica, Redondo, and San Pedro. It seems, therefore, that an ancient difference of custom separated the islanders from the bulk of the Gabrielino on this point.

THE SAN NICOLEÑO.

San Nicolas, the farthest seaward of the Santa Barbara Islands, foggy and wind blown, harbored a tribe of which the last survivor died more than 60 years ago. Four badly spelled words are all that has been preserved of their speech. These suffice to prove it Shoshonean: they do not establish its dialectic relation. A divergent idiom may well have developed in the isolation of this sand-swept and

rocky island. It is stated that when the last survivor was brought to Santa Barbara her speech was thoroughly unintelligible not only to the Chumash of the vicinity but to the "Pepimaros" of Santa Catalina (Pimu, Pipimar, the name of the island), of whom some were sent for from Los Angeles.

The last handful of the natives, who are said to have suffered previously in quarrels with Aleuts imported by Russian fur hunters, and whose numbers had probably been diminished by drafts to the missions, were taken to the mainland in 1835, soon after secularization. A woman who at the last moment missed her child was left behind. Eighteen years later, when California was American, she was discovered. Her romantic case aroused the greatest interest, and she was given the best of treatment in her new home at Santa Barbara; but she died in a few months. More attention was bestowed on her humble belongings than on the panoply of many a tribe; and while the objects themselves seem all to have been scattered and lost—the last traceable piece perished in the San Francisco fire of 1906—the descriptions, together with random but rather full recoveries from ancient village sites, enable a partial insight into the life of this remote little group, the most westerly of all Uto-Aztekan.

Wood was scarce and small on the island. There was enough brush for huts, but most dwellings were reared on a frame of whale ribs and jaws, either covered with sea-lion hides or wattled with brush or rushes. Bone implements were very numerous, and the use of several varieties is far from clear. The island may have afforded sufficient timber for plank canoes, or dugouts may have been burned from drift logs. Steatite was imported from Santa Catalina, but is represented by small ornaments or charms rather than heavy bowls. Whales must have been very abundant and frequently stranded; there is nothing to indicate that they were hunted. Sea otters were to be had in comparative profusion, and, to judge from the habits of other tribes, their furs formed the most prized dress and the chief export in a trade on which the San Nicoleño must have depended for many necessities. Seals, water birds, fish, and mollusks were no doubt the principal food; but roots were dug industriously. Baskets are spoken of as of the type ordinary in southern California. They were often asphalted, hot pebbles being employed to melt and spread the lumps. Water baskets were in plain twining, as among the Chumash; but the neck was long, much as in our wine bottles. The lone woman wore a sort of gown of squares of bird skin sewn together; but this does not seem wholly aboriginal. The usual dress may be conjectured to have been the scant costume of all California, with capes or blankets of woven strips of bird skin added at need.

The cylinder-headed wooden war club was in use. The dead were buried, as by all the islanders, not cremated as on the Shoshonean mainland. Of religion we only know that there were weather invocations and hunting charms; whether the toloache cult or the image form of mourning anniversary had reached the island must remain in abeyance; and as to society, there is total ignorance.

Ghalas-at has been given as the name of the island. This is perhaps the native or the Chumash pronunciation of Gabrielino Haras-nga.